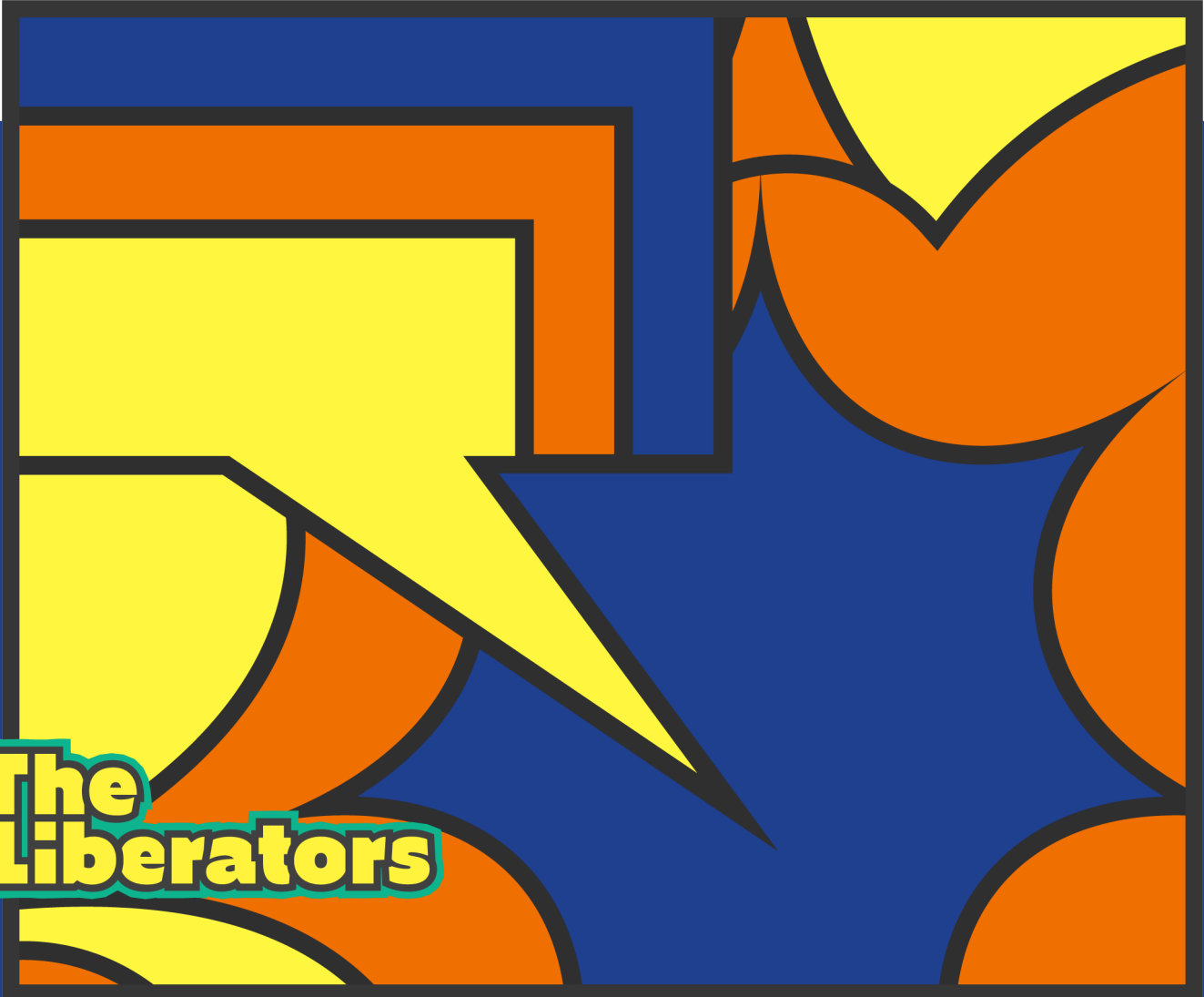


# Create A Recurring Opportunity For Management To Support Scrum Teams

A do-it-yourself workshop to let Scrum teams and management collaborate on where and how to improve, with "UX Fishbowl"



**The  
Liberators**

# The Purpose Of This Workshop

Hey there,

It is next to impossible to succeed with Scrum if you don't have support from the managers that shape the environment that you work in with your team. At the same, we know that such support is often lacking in many organizations.

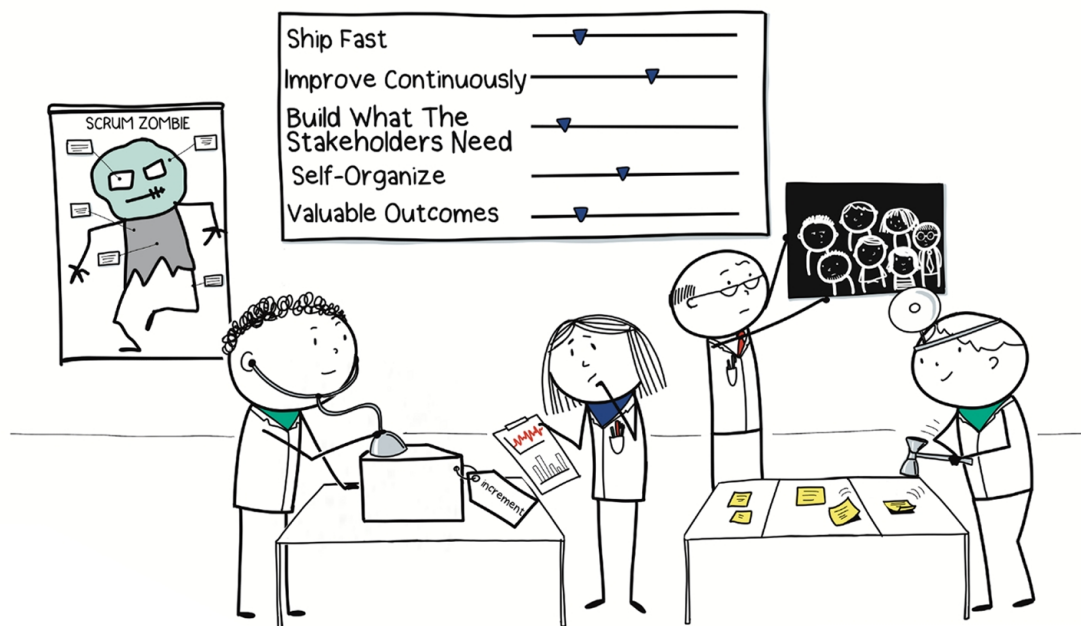
We've found that this lack of support is more often a problem of communication than a problem of intent. Both managers and Scrum teams regularly don't have a good structure to periodically ask for, and give, support where it is needed.

We designed this do-it-yourself workshop to create such a structure. In only an hour, managers can get a good sense of where their support is needed. Although the approach may be a new experience for many managers, we've found that they are usually blown away by the richness of the communication. The design of this workshop also lends itself to doing it frequently.

Give this workshop a try, and let us know the results.

*Barry & Christiaan*

**The Liberators**



Created by Theo Schukken for the Zombie Scrum Survival Guide  
by Christiaan Verwijs, Johannes Schartau & Barry Overeem  
[zombiescrum.org](http://zombiescrum.org)

# Flow



## Step 1: Opening

 1 min

## Step 2: Identify Challenges With "6x6 Writing"

  12 min

## Step 3: Share Challenges With Management With "UX Fishbowl"

  30 min

## Step 4: Personal Next Steps

  15 min

## Step 5: Closing

 2 min

## Total duration

 60 min

# Difficulty / Effort



### Required Skill



This workshop uses a basic structure, and shouldn't be hard to facilitate.

### Impact On Survival



Do it and once and reap some benefits, but do it frequently and overcome hard impediments.



# How To Prepare



## Group Size

This workshop is feasible from 8 participants and onward, and takes 60 minutes. You can easily scale this workshop up to many Scrum teams, either by running parallel UX Fishbowls or by making the inner circle bigger (although 7 is our recommended limit) and creating more outer circles.

## Intended Audience

We designed this workshop for one or more Scrum teams and including the managers that shape their immediate environment. In large organizations, this likely includes people from middle management positions; team managers, department managers, and HR managers. But in smaller organizations, we highly recommend including top-level management too. If you're up for it, you can certainly include more people from the environment of Scrum teams.

## Virtual Delivery

Liberating Structures work well virtually. Here too, they allow you to unleash and involve everyone. What is exceptionally important, however, is that you have the right tools. Because Liberating Structures are fundamentally about breaking down large-group interactions into smaller groups, you need tools that allow you to create subchannels or breakout rooms easily. [Zoom](#) is ideal for this, but similar features are available in tools like [Teams](#) and [GotoMeeting](#). We also recommend a virtual whiteboard where you can collect shared insights, like [Mural](#), [Miro](#), or [Google Slides](#). Even [Slack](#) can work.

## Preparation

- Prepare slides or supporting materials for the various rounds and their invitations.
- If you do this in person, you can already set up an equal number of chairs as you have participants. Create an inner circle of 3–5 chairs, and the rest as outer circles. We always like to keep the circles tight, so that people are seated close together.
- You can either invite participants for the inner circle (the fishbowl) upfront, or decide it in the moment. Whatever you do, make sure there is a mix of management and members of the Scrum team(s) present.



## Step 1: Opening

Start at the scheduled time. People who drop in later can jump in then. We always start our gatherings by simply saying "Hi!", followed by our name. We then explain the purpose and start with the first structure. Superfast!

We've learned that the best way to drain energy is to talk for a long time, to ask everyone to introduce themselves, or to wait for people to drop in.



## Step 2: Identify Challenges With "6x6 Writing"

Before we start the User Experience Fishbowl that is at the heart of this workshop, we're first going to help participants prepare their thoughts. A great Liberating Structure for this is [10x10 Writing](#) – although we're using 6 prompts here.

### Invitation

1. I know we make a difference in our work when ...
2. The relationship between this team and management is ...
3. Our ability to deliver value to our stakeholders is complicated by ...
4. If only management could ...
5. A tiny shift we should be able to make together is to ...
6. A hope I have for our future is that ...

### Steps

1. **1 min** Whether you're doing this virtually or in-person, ask everyone to sit down and take an empty piece of paper or an empty page in a notebook.
2. **2 min** Explain that you'll offer 6 sentences, one by one and that participants have a minute per sentence to write down the sentence and complete it with as many examples as they can think of. Emphasize that this is done in silence and in private.
3. **6 min** One by one, offer a sentence and wait one minute to give people time to write down as many examples as they can think of.
4. **2 min** Ask everyone to take a look at what they wrote down. Ask: "Looking back over your answers, silently mark patterns that immediately jump out at you"



## Step 3: Share Challenges With Management With "UX Fishbowl"

Now that we've given participants time to get their thinking started about impediments, we're moving into the stage of the workshop where they are shared. The Liberating Structure [User Experience Fishbowl](#) is a great way to do this in a structured manner, while also allowing for a casual conversation.

### Invitation

"Talk to each other about what it is like to work as a Scrum team in this organization. Where do you see opportunities and challenges?"

### Steps

1. If you do this in-person, create an inner circle of chairs (3 to 5). If you decided on whom to invite for the inner circle beforehand, ask them to take a seat. Otherwise, ask who would like to volunteer. Make sure that there is a good mix of management and members from the Scrum team(s). Everyone else positions their seats in close concentric circles around the inner circle. If you do this virtually, the inner circle turns on microphones and webcams and everyone else turns theirs off.
2. **10 min** State the invitation of the UX Fishbowl and invite the inner circle to start an informal conversation about it, as if they're in a car together or at a coffee shop. The outer circles listen and observe with full attention, take notes and remain silent throughout.
3. **4 min** Invite everyone in the outer circles to form small groups (2–3 people) and use their notes to identify big questions or ideas that might help overcome a challenge. Collect the questions so that the inner circle can use them as input for the next round. If you do this step virtually, you can form breakouts for the small groups.
4. **10 min** Invite the inner circle to go through the submitted ideas and questions in whatever order works for them. The outer circles listen and take notes, and turn off their webcam and microphone when done virtually. Continue until all submitted ideas and questions have been addressed, or until the timebox expires.

### Our Findings

- As a facilitator, gently block interruptions from the outer to the inner circle during rounds 2 and 4. In order to create space, it is important to protect the structure.
- If you do this more frequently, work hard to mix the people that participate in the inner circle.

### Resources

- The [original article](#) from the Liberating Structures website
- The [article](#) we wrote about User Experience Fishbowl
- Blog post: [Building Understanding Between Scrum Teams and Management with Liberating Structures](#)



## Step 4: Personal Next Steps

We always close by asking people to write down a personal next step. This way, everyone can contribute to the solution in whatever way is possible for them. Many small steps together easily accumulate to large change.

### Invitation

"Now that we're here, what are your personal 15% Solution to contribute to the improvements we identified?  
What is something you can do without permission from others or resources you don't have access to?"

### Steps

1. **3 min** Ask everyone to silently generate a list of personal 15% Solutions.
2. **5 min** Form pairs and invite each pair into their own breakouts. In the breakouts, people take turns to share their 15% Solutions. We always encourage listeners to help their partner find a way to guarantee that they will actually do those things (e.g. make it smaller, simpler).

### Our Findings

- It is tempting for people to complicate their 15% Solutions, which makes it unlikely they'll actually do them. You can encourage people by asking them "What is the thing you're going to do to work on that [original idea]?"
- You can make individual 15% Solutions transparent on your virtual whiteboard. But make sure that this is optional.

### Resources

- The original article on [15% Solutions](#) on the Liberating Structures website
- Blog post: Trigger BIG change by starting small with ["15% Solutions"](#)

#### Step 1

Position yourself in the scenario you recognize the most and write down a personal next step.

What is an improvement that you can make, without needing approval from someone else or resources you don't have access to?

#### Step 2

Pair up and share your 15% Solution while giving and getting help to refine your next step



## Step 5: Closing

With this workshop, you've given the Scrum teams and management an opportunity to discover where they can ask for, and give support. If this worked well for your team, we recommend that you use the closing to schedule to do this again.

If you've got any questions, comments, or ideas: always feel free to reach out and share them with us.

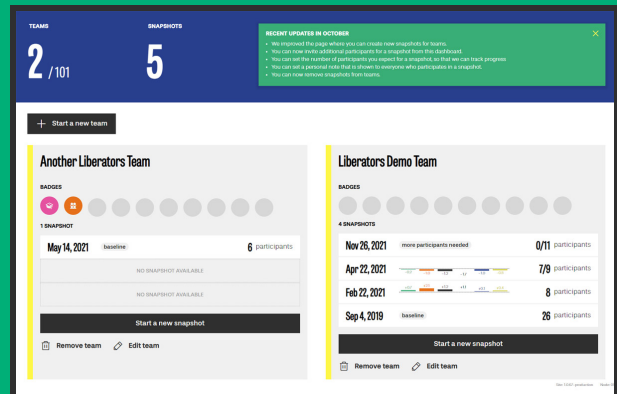
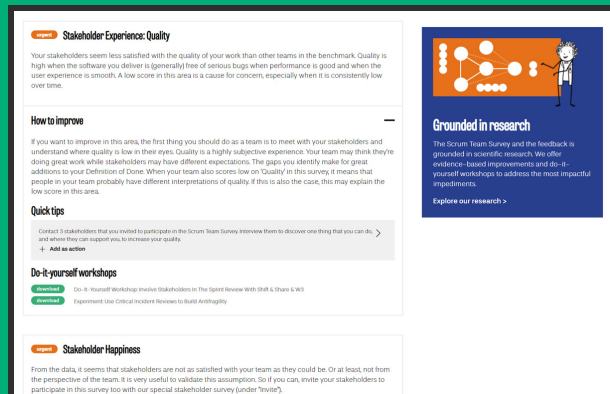
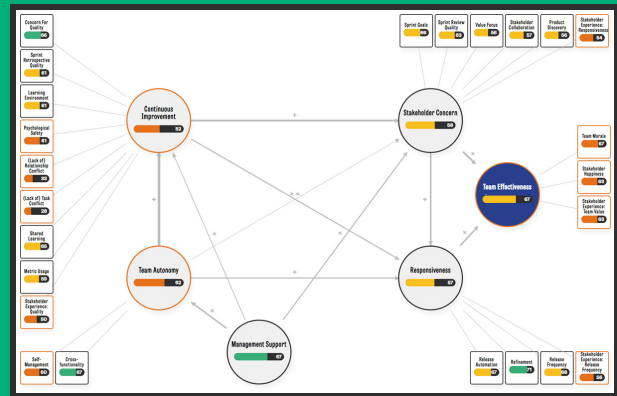
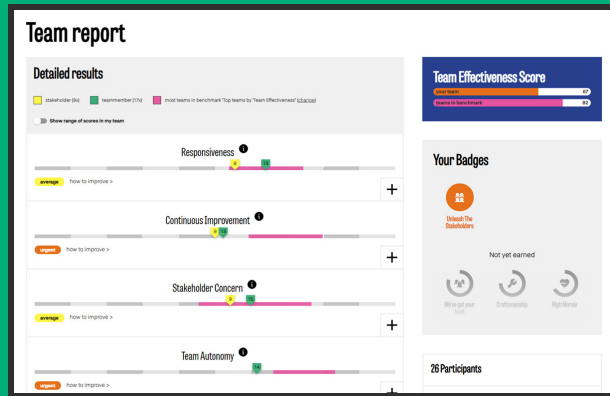
Let's learn and grow, together!





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|                                                         | Essential  | Liberator   |
|---------------------------------------------------------|------------|-------------|
| Invite team members & stakeholders                      | unlimited  | unlimited   |
| Quick Tips for your team per topic                      | 3          | unlimited   |
| Recommendations to your team                            | 5          | unlimited   |
| Compare your team against different benchmarks          |            | ✓           |
| Analyze the range of scores in your team                |            | ✓           |
| Receive our personal guidance on how to get started     |            | ✓           |
| See where your team improves over time with Team Trends |            | ✓           |
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| <b>Pricing per team per month</b>                       | <b>€ 0</b> | <b>€ 10</b> |

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